

Marking-Up Mark

Mark was the first, but was it also the worst?

Despite the order of the gospels in the New Testament, Mark is actually the earliest one. Reading the gospels in the order in which they were written shows a clear progression in how Jesus is portrayed.

MARK ~65–70 CE THE EARLIEST NARRATIVE GOSPEL	MATTHEW ~80–90 CE EDITS AND EXPANDS MARK IT CONTAINS ABOUT 80-90% OF MARK'S MATERIAL	LUKE ~80–90 CE EDITS AND EXPANDS MARK (AND POSSIBLY MATTHEW) IT CONTAINS ABOUT 50-60% OF MARK'S MATERIAL	JOHN ~90–100 CE MOSTLY INDEPENDENT
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TEXTUAL EVIDENCE OF THE DEVELOPING GOSPEL TRADITION				
	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
TOPICS MARK ADDRESSES				
Jesus' baptism	Implies Jesus was baptized for repentance and forgiveness, just like everyone else (1:1-9)	Jesus tells John he's being baptized in order to "fulfill all righteousness" (3:13-15)	Agrees with Mark, but expands John's message to the crowds (3:7-17)	No mention of repentance or forgiveness; John says the purpose of the baptism was to reveal Jesus to Israel (1:31)
Jesus' historical error	Jesus erroneously refers to Abiathar as being the high priest at a time when it was actually Ahimelech (2:26)	Keeps the surrounding story, but omits Jesus' reference to Abiathar (12:1-8)	Agrees with Matthew (6:1-5)	N/A
Jesus' family tries to restrain him	Jesus' family tries to restrain him because people were saying "He has gone out of his mind." (3:21)	Omits this story	Omits this story	N/A
Jesus' veiled/secret teachings	Jesus tells his disciples that he uses parables to veil the "secret of the kingdom of God... so that [common people] may not turn again and be forgiven" (4:10-12)	Omits the detail about the impediment to forgiveness (13:10-17)	Agrees with Matthew (8:9-10)	N/A
Jesus' lack of power	"And he could do no deed of power there, except that he laid his hands on a few sick people and cured them. And he was amazed at their unbelief." (6:5-6)	"And he did not do many deeds of power there, because of their unbelief." (13:58)	Omits this story	N/A
Jesus' unusual healing technique	Jesus uses saliva on his fingers to heal a man who was deaf and mute (7:31-35)	Never mentions saliva in any of the healing stories	Same as Matthew	See next row
Jesus' two-step healing	Jesus again uses saliva as he heals a blind man, but this time it requires a second attempt (8:22-26)	Never mentions a healing that required multiple attempts	Same as Matthew	Contains a similar story about Jesus using his saliva to heal a blind man, but here it works on the first attempt. (9:1-7)
Jesus' predicts his resurrection	Jesus predicts his rejection and death, and his resurrection: "... and after three days rise again." (8:31; repeated in 9:31)	Changes the resurrection timeline: "...and on the third day be raised." (16:21; repeated in 17:23)	Agrees with Matthew (9:22; Luke omits the second occurrence of the saying)	N/A
Who is "good"?	"Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus said to him, "Why do you call me good? No one is good but God alone." (10:17-18)	"Teacher, what good deed must I do to have eternal life?" And he said to him, "Why do you ask me about what is good? There is one who is good." (19:16-17)	Agrees with Mark (18:18-19)	N/A
Foreknowledge of end times	"But about that day or hour no one knows, neither the angels in heaven nor the Son, but only the Father." (13:32)	Agrees with Mark (24:36)	Omits this saying	N/A
Jesus' anguish in Gethsemane	Jesus is distressed and agitated in Gethsemane; he throws himself on the ground to pray; he prays three times for deliverance (14:32-42)	Agrees with Mark (26:36-46)	No mention of Jesus being distressed or agitated; he kneels to pray, and it's only once. Note: Luke 22:43–44, which says Jesus' sweat was like drops of blood, is not in the earliest and most reliable manuscripts.	Jesus does not pray or show any distress in Gethsemane
Who carried Jesus' cross?	Simon of Cyrene carries Jesus' cross for him (15:21)	Agrees with Mark (27:32)	Agrees with Mark (23:26)	Jesus carries the cross by himself (19:17)
Jesus' final words on the cross	"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (15:34)	Agrees with Mark (27:46)	"Father, into your hands I commend my spirit." (23:46)	"It is finished." (19:30)
TOPICS MARK IS SILENT ON				
Jesus' miraculous conception	Not mentioned	The Holy Spirit impregnates Jesus' virgin mother (1:18)	Agrees with Matthew, but adds "...therefore the child to be born will be holy; he will be called Son of God." (1:35)	Jesus is an eternally pre-existent being who has always been with, and equal with, God (1:1-14)
The Trinitarian commission	Not mentioned	"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit." (28:19)	N/A	N/A
Post-resurrection appearances	The earliest and most reliable manuscripts end with 16:8 and thus do not contain post-resurrection appearances	Jesus appears to the three women who visited the tomb (28:9), and later to the disciples on a mountain in Galilee (28:16-17)	Jesus appears to two disciples on the road to Emmaus (24:13-35); later that same day he appears to all of the disciples in Jerusalem (24:33-43)	Jesus appears to all of the disciples except Thomas, and shows them his hands and his pierced side (20:19-20); eight days later, he again appears to all of the disciples, including Thomas (20:26-29)
The ascension	Not mentioned	N/A	"While he was blessing them, he withdrew from them and was carried up into heaven." (24:50-53)	N/A
Worshiping Jesus	Not mentioned	The disciples worship Jesus after he walks on water (14:33), and after his resurrection (28:9,17)	The disciples worship Jesus after his ascension (24:50-53)	Jesus is worshiped by the man whose blindness he healed (9:38)
BOTTOM LINE				
Was Jesus just a man, or was he God?	The most human portrayal of Jesus: no divine pedigree, limited power and knowledge, and openly emotional	A clear elevation in divine status and overall behavior, but he's still emotional as the end draws near	Similar to Matthew's Jesus, but here he's much less emotional in Gethsemane and on the cross	This Jesus seems barely human: he has no limitations, and he's continuously stoic and resolute, especially in the face of death